MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume V | Issue II | Spring 2015



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655 EUNICE AVE.
HISTORICAL MILESTONES



1924 Nicholas Kristmas builds 7,200-sf, 18-room farmhouse on the property, which still stands today. At the time, the house was located in Mountain View's countryside.

1928 A speakeasy was established on the property, known at different times as the Blue & Gold Kennel Club, the Whitehall Distillery, and Burton's Gold Medal Distillery.

1933 Alleged-gangster George "Tex" White, from Chicago was arrested for using live rabbits to train greyhound racing dogs on the property.

1938 A shooting occurs, leading federal authorities to seize the property and put it up for sale on the auction block, ending its era of local infamy.

1939 Harold Skinner purchases the property. The greyhound racetrack and bleachers are removed during WW II. Skinner lives in the house until his death in 1961.

1962 Irwin and Gilda Wunderman purchase the property and continue Skinner's legacy of preserving many of its unique, historic, Prohibition-era features.

SPRING 2015 MVHA EVENT: A SPEAKEASY AFTERNOON AT THE FORMER
BLUE & GOLD "KENNEL CLUB"

Take a walk on the wild side! Mark your calendars! We're excited to announce that the Mtn. View Historical Association is presenting a most unusual and fantastic Spring event and Membership Meeting for 2015. It will take place at the Wunderman House, 655 Eunice Avenue on Sunday May 3rd, from 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.

The house's colorful past began in the 1920s when it was built and put into operation as a Prohibition-era speakeasy! Once called the **"Blue & Gold Kennel Club,"** it was a front for illicit activities.

Guided tours of the house, now a private residence, will be available during the event—with food, drink, and music on the grounds. Learn about the goings-on during a different era in Mountain View's history where the "dolls were loose and the bathtub gin flowed."

Highlights of the Wunderman House include the basement with its original ballroom and a private bar once used by bordello customers. Your liaison and good-humored madam for the event will be our own President Pat Figueroa, who invites everyone to enjoy this fun afternoon soiree.

This event is free and open to our members, guests, and the general public—but space is limited! So, in the spirit of the speakeasy and to control crowds, a special **password** is required to access the grounds ! Password provided upon RSVP.



A sneek peak into Mountain View's most infamous speakeasy!

To get the secret password, e-mail:
info@mountainviewhistorical.org

Or RSVP on the event page on Facebook:
www.facebook.com/MVHistory

Or leave a message with your name and contact information by calling:
(650) 903 6890

In the slang of the Roaring '20s, this event will be the "bee's knees." We look forward to seeing you there!





MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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Director-at-Large: Lisa Roquero Garcia
Hospitality: Helene Hughes
Programs: Bob Weaver
Publicity: Mary Kay Marinovich

In Memoriam

Ada B. Givich
Dec. 29, 1921 – Feb. 27, 2015

News & Notes



Your MVHA Board, hard at work during the Winter Board Meeting at the Mountain View History Center

President's Message

By Patricia Figueroa
MVHA President

I'd like to personally thank the February Membership Meeting participants in our "When Shoreline Was Stierlin" panel. Each of them brought such a different perspective, and we all had such fun going down memory lane.

At our March Board meeting, we discussed how we were going to participant in community activities. The first step is the City Parade; Eugene and Nancy Sharp are very kindly willing to drive their cars (a Volvo convertible and a 1936 Buick) in the parade. Passengers in the cars will be a combination of MVHA Board members and members—so don't forget to mark your calendars for April 25th, and give us a big "hi" as we pass by.

We're all looking forward to our Spring event on May 3rd at the historic Wunderman House on Eunice Avenue. Don't forget to RSVP to get the password! See page 1 for more information. Looking ahead to early Summer—we're planning on participating in the first "Thursday Night Live" event of the year on June 25. In addition to setting up an info table on Castro Street, we'll be testing out what will hopefully be the first of a quarterly series of historic walking tours of Downtown Mountain View. Nick Perry will be leading the tour. To sign up, visit our table that evening!

Finally, thanks to our webmaster, Suzette Spencer, for updating our e-mail accounts. If you need to reach me (or future MVHA presidents), simply e-mail: president@mountainviewhistorical.org.

'Tis all for now. Hope to see you all at the Wunderman House!

Editor's Note

By Nick Perry
MVHA Newsletter Editor

A big THANK YOU to MVHA Member Cynthia Hanson for volunteering her services as a professional copy editor to help me edit our newsletter! We're constantly looking to improve the newsletter so if you have ideas, letters to the editor, or content to contribute, please contact us. We have a new e-mail set up for the newsletter: newsletter@mountainviewhistorical.org

Financial Report

By John Figueroa
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 12/10/14: $ 4,936.57

- Income: $1,076.67
- Expenses: $682.59

Checking Account Balance as of 3/11/15: $ 5,330.65

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 12/10/14: $83,137.44

History Center Update

By Candace Bowers
MVHA Vice President

New to the History Center:
From Ken Alsman: Aerial of Shoreline Park and photo slides from his career as a Mtn. View City Planner from 1968–1995.

New Volunteer!
Meet Michelle Chimento (photo on right), History Center volunteer. Michelle has a master's degree in library and information science, and has experience with archives and genealogy collections. Since September, she has been working several days a week in the History Center, indexing the information in our files and creating research guides. Thank you, Michelle!



Join Our History Center Team!
The Mountain View History Center is looking for volunteers to join our team. Help us share Mountain View's historic archives with the public. With your help, we can offer longer hours and greater access to this invaluable resource. For more information, contact Candace Bowers at **candace.bowers@mountainview.gov**

The History Center

Mountain View Public Library, 2nd Floor
585 Franklin Street, Mtn. View, CA 94041

Open from 1:00-5:00 p.m. every Tuesday & by appointment.
Call (650) 903 6890 for more information.

The Mtn. History Center's mission is to collect, organize and make available Mountain View historical resources and to promote the city's heritage. It contains the historic archives of both the MVHA and the Mtn. View Public Library. Mtn. View history books and pamphlets are also available for purchase at the History Center.

Immigrant House Update

By Marina Marinovich
MVHA Publicity Chair



At the community meeting held March 5th in the MV Senior Center, residents made a strong push for the creation of a new park at 771 North Rengstorff Avenue that preserves the existing wooded environment and includes new gardens, fixtures, benches, and lighting, and a new home for the city's historic Immigrant House. Residents in attendance were passionate about the proposed park. More than 50 people attended the meeting at the Senior Center, including representation from MVHA. Generally all agreed that the 1.2-acre park should not have the parking lots and grass turf that are typical of most parks in the city.

It has taken three years and the efforts of many community members to preserve Immigrant House; the 1880s structure was originally located downtown at 166 Bryant Street. Many people would like to see it become a static period-correct display of everyday life for the 1880s to 1920s immigrants. The 400-square-foot house is currently in a city storage yard and is slated to be restored and moved into the new park.

The Stiepers—the park's former owners—laid out and preserved the property as a wooded oasis; every inch of it is like a precious jewel. If you were to take a bird's-eye view of the property, you would see that it is set in a sea of concrete. As Mountain View continues to grow at an accelerated pace, we need balance; we need an area to just "chill" with nature. Let's let the bees be the busiest thing on the property. Resident Deb Henigson said "Let me teach my daughter about all the trees" in the park, that is generously shaded by 164 trees, including fruit trees—apricots, figs, avocados, peaches, apples, oranges, and plums—trees that were planted in huge groves in the area's early history.

The neighbors whose apartments overlook the park said they enjoy the fact that it seems to be a haven for wildlife. Someone suggested that it become a part of a Garden for Wildlife Program. One person at the meeting suggested that parking would be necessary for people interested in helping with gardening, but many others immediately disagreed, saying the park should be mostly for the neighborhood and those who choose to walk or bike there. "I don't want to add parking spaces, but it would be nice to add bicycle racks," said one man. No one argued in favor of cutting into the wooded 1.2-acre space for parking after that.

A gift to Immigrant House is tax-deductible. Your 501(c) tax-deductible contribution will ensure that our stories, and those of our ancestors, are told for generations to come. Go to the Los Altos Community Foundation website http://tinyurl.com/k7fdpbb, and donate today! Contact Friends of Immigrant House, Mary Kay "Marina" Marinovich, (650) 961-8209.

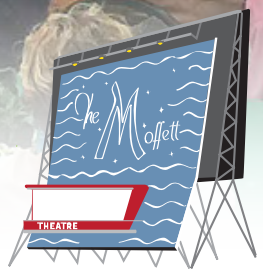
WINTER 2014 EVENT RECAP













When Shoreline Was Stierlin: Memories of the North Bayshore







At our Winter Adobe Building Event on February 22, we were treated to a fascinating panel discussion on the history of Mountain View's rapidly changing North Bayshore area. Our six panelists included Helen Hughes and Karen McGough, who both grew up in the area when it was still rural; Bob Lawrence, Ken Alsman, and Kevin Duggan, three former city employees whose collective planning and leadership guided the area's growth from the 1960s to the 2010s; and Ginny Kaminkski, a longtime volunteer with Shoreline at Mountain View and the Rengstorff House.

The discussion was moderated by our Newsletter Editor, Nick Perry, and covered a wide range of topics—from rural farm life, roving Hells Angels gangs, early city negotiations with developers, the transformation of the city dump into Shoreline at Mountain View, and even some ghost stories from the Rengstorff House! Our Historical Data Chair, Eugene Sharp, filmed the discussion, and we are investigating whether to air it on KMVT. We are also working on transcribing the conversation for our archives.

For some memorable quotes from each of our panelists, take a look at the next page. A big THANK YOU to each of them and everyone who joined us! Hope to see you at our next event!





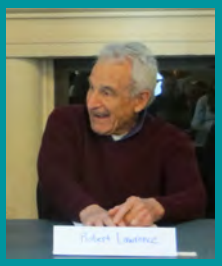


Memorable Quotes



"I lived on Stierlin Road right where the amphitheater is—so I have all the celebrities in my backyard! I was from a family of five people. My mother and father had a nice farm with an acre and a half. We had every fruit tree, every animal, all on that acre and a half. It was a very nice life, a small community of small farmers so to see it become one of the richest areas in the world is purely amazing to me."

–Helen Hughes, grew up on a farm on the site of Shoreline Amphitheatre



"Just before the war, the freeway had been built, 101. As I recall, it seemed like that area was kind of divorced from the rest of the town. I remember when I first came here in the 1960s I thought, "Gee, this is a town with a waterfront, but not many people were even aware that there was a water frontage to our community."

–Robert (Bob) Lawrence, Mountain View Planning Director, 1962–1975



"The North Bayshore was the Wild West. It really was. I know people living there saw it as kind of being a really wonderful place. But for this guy from New Jersey, it was the Wild West. The roads were kind of funky. There were Hells Angels living in a couple of the houses out there. You could always find some sort of a cock fight or something going on in the neighborhood. And I distinctly remember a guy living in a teepee! I don't know why."

–Ken Alsman, Mountain View City Planner, 1968–1995



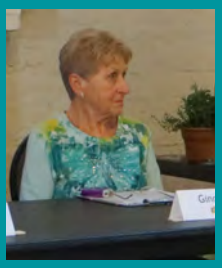
"One story that I remember that really emphasizes the changes that have been made—my street, Plymouth Street, went across Bayshore. It wasn't called 101, it was Bayshore. With a stop sign! And the little store on our side didn't carry magazines, but the one on the other side did, and we used to walk across Bayshore to buy our magazines and walk back home. So, quite a change!"

–Karen Howard McGough, grew up in one of the last houses still standing in the North Bayshore



"...they [Bob Lawrence and Ken Alsman] decided to pay me $3 an hour to go out on foot and walk through the entire area and survey what was actually out there. The main thing I remember was being chased by every junkyard dog. There were some wonderful people out there, really interesting land uses, a real variety of things, and some real mean dogs!"

–Kevin Duggan, Mountain View City Manager, 1990–2011 and Planning Intern, 1971–1972



"I had a fellow stop by [the Rengstorff House] one day and said he had lived there as a rental property with his family, and he said he had "feelings" about the house. So I said, "Tell me about your feelings!" He said "….well, things happened." He said he had a broken leg and he was upstairs in bed, and there's a door that went up to the widow's walk. There was a dresser against it, and that dresser moved, and he felt an impression at the end of his bed. Several other people have mentioned things. Our maintenance man who would come early in the mornings said he would put things in one spot or turn a light on and go outside to do something, and things had changed. So, I would be working there [alone] late at night and I'd say "If anybody wants to tell me anything, I'll listen to ya!"

–Ginny Kaminski, former Program Coordinator, Shoreline at Mountain View

Street Talk

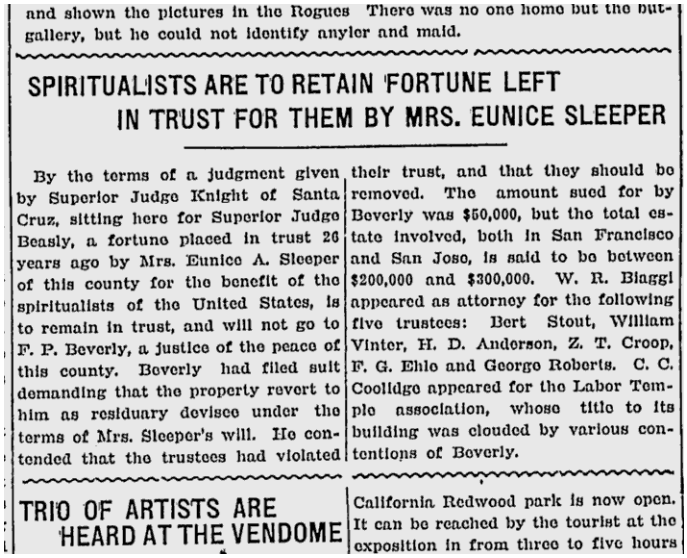


By Candace Bowers
MVHA Vice President

In anticipation of our Spring event at 655 Eunice Avenue, let's take a look back at the history of the street and its neighbor to the north, Sleeper Avenue. If you live on Eunice Avenue today, you might not be able to tell from your cheerful, modern surroundings that your street has a link to Mountain View's earliest settlers—and an "otherwordly" connection, too.

Eunice Avenue was named for Eunice Sleeper, who was married to one of Mountain View's early pioneers, Frank Sleeper. A prominent citizen in her own right, Eunice was also an ardent spiritualist.

Eunice was born 1813 in Maine, and came to California in 1850 with her husband. They settled in Mountain View in 1852. Their land was bordered by present-day El Camino Real, Phyllis Avenue, and Stevens Creek, and included the land that later became the Dale Ranch. Frank served as a school trustee and member of the County Board of Supervisors. After he died in 1872, Eunice—having no surviving children—created the Sleeper Trust, funded by the sale of her considerable land holdings and dedicated to her and her husband's shared cause: spiritualism.



and shown the pictures in the Rogues There was no one home but the butgallery, but he could not identify anyler and maid.

SPIRITUALISTS ARE TO RETAIN FORTUNE LEFT IN TRUST FOR THEM BY MRS. EUNICE SLEEPER

By the terms of a judgment given by Superior Judge Knight of Santa Cruz, sitting here for Superior Judge Beasly, a fortune placed in trust 26 years ago by Mrs. Eunice A. Sleeper of this county for the benefit of the spiritualists of the United States, is to remain in trust, and will not go to F. P. Beverly, a justice of the peace of this county. Beverly had filed suit demanding that the property revert to him as residuary devisee under the terms of Mrs. Sleeper's will. He contended that the trustees had violated their trust, and that they should be removed. The amount sued for by Beverly was $50,000, but the total estate involved, both in San Francisco and San Jose, is said to be between $200,000 and $300,000. W. R. Biaggi appeared as attorney for the following five trustees: Bert Stout, William Vinter, H. D. Anderson, Z. T. Croop, F. G. Ehle and George Roberts. C. C. Coolidge appeared for the Labor Temple association, whose title to its building was clouded by various contentions of Beverly.

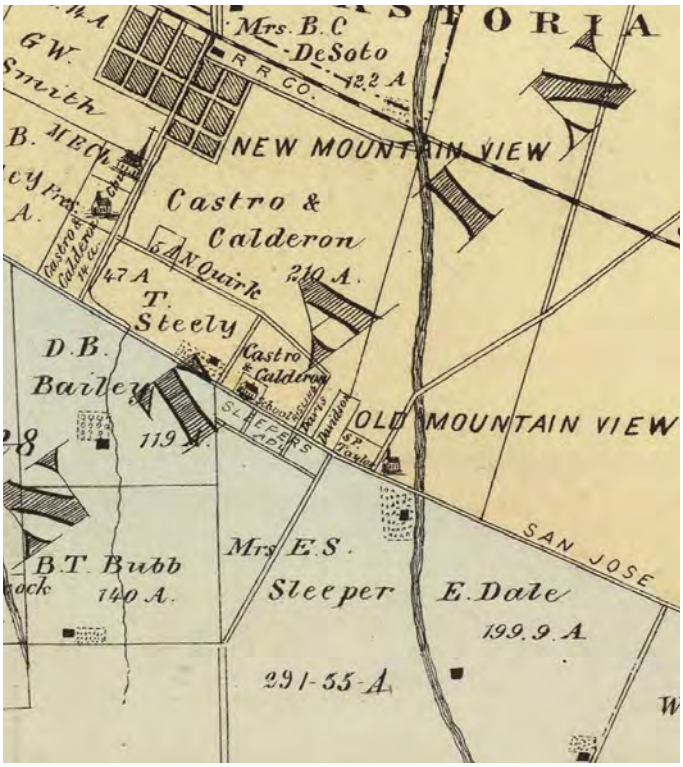
TRIO OF ARTISTS ARE HEARD AT THE VENDOME

California Redwood park is now open. It can be reached by the tourist at the exposition in from three to five hours

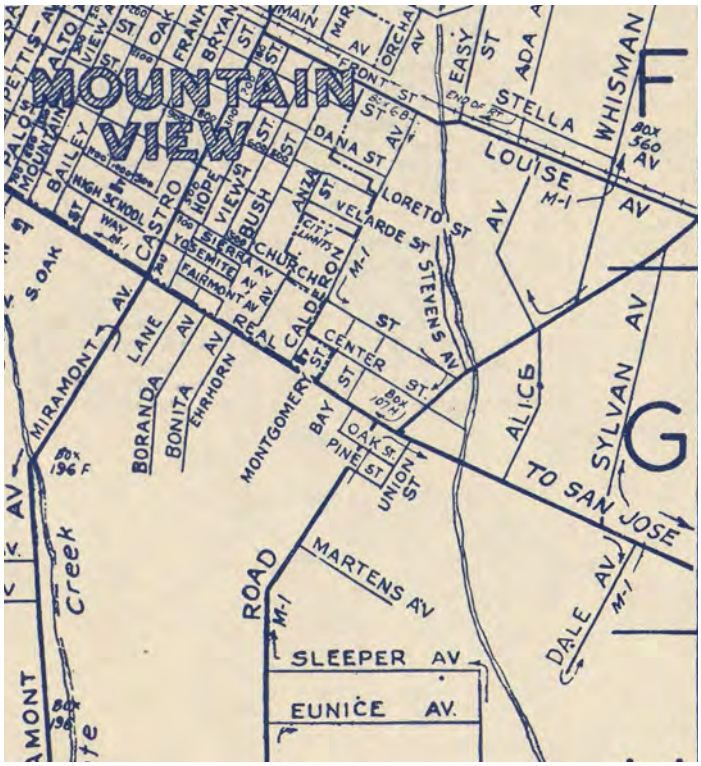
April 30, 1915 *San Jose Evening News* Article

At the time, spiritualism—the belief that the dead can communicate with the living (and are encouraged to do so)—was quite popular, if not mainstream. The Trust was able to support spiritualist endeavors as well as pay Eunice's living expenses at the Pratt Home for Old Ladies in San Jose. In 1899, the Trust bought the former YMCA building in downtown San Jose; renamed as Sleeper Hall, it became the headquarters for the First Spiritual Union of San Jose. It also hosted meetings of other local groups, and was the site of Eunice's own funeral in 1901. Sleeper Hall later became the San Jose Labor Temple, of which Jack London is said to have been a member. The building was torn down in the 1950s.

1876 map showing "Mrs. E.S. Sleeper Ranch"



1938 map showing Eunice and Sleeper Ave.



Maps from the David Rumsey map collection: www.davidrusmey.org

Membership

Membership Report

Submitted by June Casey
Membership Chair

Membership as of March 15, 2015

Honored Members	2
Life Members	114
Family Members	76
Single Members	116
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**308**

Welcome to our new members!
New Life Members: Robert Cox and Bob Stenz
New Members: Lt. Roderick B. Bersamina.

Volunteer Opportunities

The MVHA always welcomes volunteers interested in lending their time and talents to our organization. Listed below are current volunteer opportunities.

History Center Volunteers: See Page 3 for more info.

Event Tabling Volunteers: Greet the public at the MVHA's table at upcoming events. See Page 8 for upcoming events.

Walking Tour Guides: The MVHA is planning to offer historical walking tours of Old Mountain View this Summer! We're looking to train volunteers to help lead tours of small groups around Castro Street.

To sign up for the above volunteer opportunities, send an email to info@mountainviewhistorical.org or call (650) 903-6890.

Faces of the MVHA

Our organization is nothing without its wonderful members! In this new feature, we shine a spotlight on members who agreed to share a little bit about themselves at our most recent membership meeting.



Adam & Kat Blankenheimer

Year joined:
2014

Connection to Mtn. View:
"We moved here after we got married in June, 2014."

Favorite thing about the MVHA:
"The pictures people bring to meetings are wonderful! And the cookies aren't bad either..."

Favorite spot in Mtn. View:
"We love taking in the sights on Castro Street, and we'll usually turn the corner on Dana to take a look at the Mountain View General Store."

MVHA MEMBERSHIP FORM

The Mountain View Historical Association welcomes new members! Association members are part of a vibrant community of people who value the history of Mountain View. By becoming a dues-paying member, you are making a special investment in the MVHA's mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, collect and conserve priceless archival materials at the Mountain View History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. Support the MVHA and join us today!

- ☐ New membership
- ☐ Renewal
- ☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*
- ☐ Family Membership: *$25/year*
- ☐ Life-time Membership *$200*
- ☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

Name: _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____

State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Telephone: _____

E-mail: _____

Please make checks payable to:
Mountain View Historical Association

Mail to:
Mtn. View Historical Association
PO Box 252, Mountain View, Ca 94042

SPRING/SUMMER

May 3
Sunday, 1:00–2:30 p.m.
MVHA Spring Event/Meeting
Wunderman House - 655 Eunice Ave.
"Blue & Gold Kennel Club," Details on Page 1

April 25
Saturday, 12:00–3:00 p.m.
MVHA @ Downtown Spring Parade
Castro Street - Downtown Mtn. View
Details on Page 2, President's Message

June 10
Wednesday, 6:00–8:00 p.m.
MVHA Board Meeting
M.V. Library History Center - 585 Franklin St.
Interested members are welcome to attend!

June 25
Thursday, 5:30–8:00 p.m.
MVHA @ Thursday Night Live
Castro Street - Downtown Mtn. View
Come say "hi" at our table and join us on a walking tour of historic Downtown!



EST. 1954

MOUNTAIN REVIEW
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, CA 94042

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E-MAIL: mvha.newsletter@gmail.com

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